"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, sunny, winds tapering off, high 56. **Tonight,** mainly clear, light winds, low 46. **Tomorrow,** some sunshine, a steady afternoon breeze, high 63. Weather map is on Page 20.

VOL. CLXXVI . . . No. 61,041 © 2026 The New York Times Company SUNDAY, OCTOBER 18, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $6.00



PHOTOGRAPHS BY BRANDON TAUSZIK FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Gorda is not an actual town in California but an outpost that includes a restaurant, three minimarts and cabins for rent.

Sea Views So Spectacular, You May Not Mind $10 Gas

By CORINA KNOLL

GORDA, Calif. — Gorda is the sort of place that one stumbles onto while headed elsewhere.

Although it is in Big Sur — that romanticized ribbon of California where the highway is carved into the mountains and the cliff walls plunge into a glittering sea — it is a modest hamlet that sits on a less prominent stretch.

There is no cell service for miles, so Gorda materializes without warning. It is not an actual town but an outpost that consists entirely of a restaurant, three minimarts and cabins for rent, along with housing for about a dozen employees in the back of the complex.

Even the people here will tell you this place is not a destination. Perhaps the most popular request of travelers is the code to the restroom.

In the spring, however, Gorda and its fuel station of four pumps received a smattering of attention.

A gallon of premium unleaded gas was going for $9.999 — the highest number many pump displays allow. (Gorda does not sell diesel, which would be even more expensive, because truckers avoid the area.)

It was an outrageous figure even in a state where the average price per gallon at the time hovered around $6, the steepest in the nation.

Ten-dollar unleaded seemed to be a symptom of war, the affordability crisis and the shriveling California dream all at once.

The owner of the station, Leonardo Vargas Flores, was not bothered. Most patrons headed only to the minimarts anyway, where the inflated cost of a small bag of chips ($5.99) never caused a stir.

It wasn't long afterward that Mr. Vargas Flores, 61, decided to call his fuel supplier

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The owner of the Gorda gas station, which depends on tourism, got the pumps' software updated so the decimal point could be moved to display amounts over $9.99.

Defense Chief Used as a Foil By Democrats

Citing Iran, Campaigns Single Hegseth Out

By ROBERT JIMISON

A Democrat in a hotly contested House district in Colorado ridiculed Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth's workout routine in a social media post promoting his congressional campaign.

Another Democratic candidate in California invoked his name as she excoriated her Republican opponent for his support for the war with Iran — which she blames for higher prices Americans are paying at the pump.

Representative Hakeem Jeffries, the New York Democrat in line to be speaker should his party win control of Congress, has repeatedly called for Mr. Hegseth to resign or to be fired. "One of the first things we're going to do in the majority," he said during a recent rally, "we're going to run Pete Hegseth out of town."

In the final weeks of a midterm congressional battle in which voters' opposition to the war with Iran has become a major issue, Democrats are increasingly making Mr. Hegseth a main character in their campaign messaging.

It is an effort to turn one of President Trump's most recognizable cabinet officials — and one who has been an unapologetic and visible cheerleader for a war that polls show is deeply unpopular — into a liability for Republicans' fighting to keep their seats.

In a recent video he posted online, Manny Rutinel, the Democrat and former state legislator who is challenging Representative Gabe Evans of Colorado in one of the most competitive races in the country, featured unflattering footage of Mr. Hegseth working out with troops.

"This man is letting Trump raise your gas prices," reads the type stamped on the video of a sweaty Mr. Hegseth seeming to struggle as he lifts weights alongside military personnel. "I'm going to put a stop to it," it reads, as the video cuts to Mr. Rutinel doing pull-ups and lifting much bigger weights at the gym.

"Pete Hegseth is helping Trump start an unplanned forever war while Americans struggle here at home," Mr. Rutinel wrote in a post circulating the video, which does not show Mr. Evans. "I'm running for Congress to stop them."

More recently in San Diego, Marni von Wilpert, a city councilwoman running for an open House seat against Jim Desmond, a Trump-endorsed Republican, used an appearance by Mr. Hegseth to call for an independent investigation into conditions aboard the U.S.S. Abraham Lincoln, the aircraft carrier that re-

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TRUMP'S ORDER EXEMPTS RUSSIA FROM SANCTIONS

NEW PENALTIES PAUSED

Law Named for Graham Aimed at Oligarchs and War Effort

By ALAN RAPPEPORT

WASHINGTON — President Trump has signed an executive order exempting Russia from a new sanctions measure that Congress passed last month, offering another economic lifeline to President Vladimir V. Putin as the United States turns to Russia for help in lowering gas prices.

The sanctions were intended to target Russian officials, oligarchs and financial institutions, to pressure the country to stop its war against Ukraine. They were part of a law named after Senator Lindsey Graham, the South Carolina Republican who died in July after spending more than a year building support for the measure.



Lindsey Graham

Washington has broad authority to issue exemptions on sanctions, and the new law says Mr. Trump is required to notify Congress if he decided against imposing economic restrictions on Russia. Two days before the law was set to take effect, Mr. Trump exercised that power on Friday night.

"I am hereby waiving the application of such sanctions, restrictions and duties provided for in the Graham Act," Mr. Trump said in the order. "I have submitted to the Congress a certification that the issuance of such a waiver at this time is in the national interests of the United States."

The order does not explain why waiving the sanctions is in the interests of the United States or what rationale Mr. Trump is providing to Congress for the waivers.

The decision comes as Mr. Trump has in recent weeks embraced Russia and expressed frustration that Ukraine's attacks on Russian refineries were helping to push up gasoline and diesel prices around the world. The biggest factor limiting supplies, though, remains the war in Iran.

"The main issue is still the Strait of Hormuz — that there is not enough diesel coming out of the Strait of Hormuz," said Sarah Raffoul, an oil product analyst at Argus Media.

The price increases have trig-

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After Sailors Are Killed in Gulf, Families Find Payouts Elusive

By JENNY GROSS

Sumit Kumar Singh, a sailor from eastern India, did not hesitate when a job opened up on a ship ferrying oil in the Persian Gulf. He knew it was dangerous work, but he needed the money.

On Sept. 12, he told his wife, Komal Priya, that his ship would soon enter the Strait of Hormuz. He said he would call her once he arrived at its destination. Instead, early the next morning, Ms. Priya received a call from a crew member saying that her husband and another sailor were missing after the ship, the El Gaia, was struck by an Iranian missile and a drone.

Oil exports from the Persian Gulf have rebounded, with more tankers moving through the Strait of Hormuz. But the journey remains incredibly risky. Since the war began, there have been more than 100 attacks. At least 26 ships have been struck this month alone, making it the most dangerous period during the war in Iran. Even as the regional conflict has escalated in Saudi Arabia and Yemen, the strait remains a deadly focus of fighting.

For going on eight months, thousands of sailors have been working on the front line of the war, supporting families far away. At least 25 of them have been killed, almost all by Iran, and four are missing. The first fatality was hours after the war began, and the most recent report of sailors who are missing or dead was on Monday.

On the El Gaia, projectiles struck the engine room, and Mr. Singh died in the ensuing fire. Grief has left Ms. Priya barely able to eat, said her brother, Aditya Raj, who recounted the family's experience. Around the house, the children, ages 4 and 7, ask where their father is.

The New York Times interviewed members of seven families, including Mr. Raj, who lost husbands, fathers and brothers to attacks in or around the Strait of Hormuz. It reviewed incident reports, communications between shipping companies and families, and life insurance records, and spoke to industry analysts and officials who were monitoring conditions in the region.

The family members described to The Times their trauma and

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JEFF PACHOUD/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE — GETTY IMAGES

Unrest in France
Riots broke out across French cities alongside peaceful marches protesting rising living costs and poor school conditions. Page 6.

Frenzied Hunt by Online Trolls To Identify Cornell's Jane Doe

This article is by ***Debra Kamin****,* ***Amy Julia Harris****,* ***Ryan Mac****,* ***Emma Goldberg*** *and* ***Hurubie Meko****.*

The online campaign to unmask Jane Doe began with pleas on X.

"Please help me discover the Cornell girl," Aidan Thompson, a 23-year-old man who regularly praises Hitler and disparages women on the social media platform, wrote in one of the first posts. "I have a good lead, but I need your help."

Within hours of Mr. Thompson's post, another user had offered a bounty of $5,000 for the name and photos of the woman who had sued Cornell University under the pseudonym, claiming she had been gang raped at a fraternity party.

Within a day, commenters were circulating a woman's name and images of her from a social media account.

On the fringes of the internet, bigots, attention-seekers and trolls have long seized on polarizing legal cases to air anger and disgust at women — and boost their following.

Now they were coming for Jane Doe.

A little more than a week after Mr. Thompson's post about the former Cornell student, more than 11,000 accounts had made almost 25,000 posts that purported to name her, according to an analysis by an online analytics company, Gudea, conducted at the request of The New York Times.

The analysis showed that the posts had begun on X and spread to Bluesky, 4chan, Discord, Telegram, Rumble and other plat-

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South Koreans Fall for a Shark
Stranded in a port waterway for weeks, the 10-foot fish has attracted more than a million spectators. Efforts to guide her back to open sea have failed. PAGE 9

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Leo left the hospital after his lung operation, but mysteries remain, prompting scrutiny. News Analysis. PAGE 8

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Chronicling a flood in the Midwest in 1993 that was powerful enough to disrupt the dead. PAGE 21



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Mikal Bridges is primed to take a big step up for the Knicks, who face the difficult task of repeating as champions.

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Most Holy Redeemer Church is temporarily closed, and congregants fear that it may not reopen. PAGE 5

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Residue from the twin towers coated homes' interiors, yet residents returned with little guidance. PAGE 1

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Nondisclosure agreements, once only for executives, have become a tool for preventing household workers from talking about their employers. PAGE 11



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How Long Can You Live?
Longevity doesn't just mean living a long time. It also means living well and being able to enjoy life, both physically and mentally.

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Emily Bazelon PAGE 4

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A Two-Man Donor Base
Two crypto billionaires each gave $48.7 million to Nigel Farage's Reform U.K. party, transforming the arithmetic of British politics. PAGE 6

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Homes for Over $100 Million
The age of the nine-figure listing is here, fueled by tax cuts, the tech boom and eager billionaires. And this year is a record one. PAGE 9